

From Icon to ITEM

The evolutionary saga of the Lion of Lahore in all its colourful details



**IMRAN KHAN
THE BIOGRAPHY**
by CHRISTOPHER
SANDFORD
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 402

| By Sharda Ugra |

Why would anyone be interested in the life of Imran Khan today? Sure, in the 1980s, he was a giant. In cricket's jazz quartet of all-rounders, the Khan was the cool drummer, whose sound was both heard and felt. He made his team winners outside their home turf, exposed the hypocrisy of the Anglo-Australian establishment relentlessly and then won Pakistan a World Cup in 1992.

In his prime, he was a pop icon who made the hearts of women in East and West beat to a synchronised chorus that would have forced Kipling to rewrite those lines. He was the guy who wore a T-shirt advertising Kerry Packer's World Series Cricket which said: "Big Boys Play At Night". No famous sponsor, no giant logo, but the sauciest line found on a cricketer's T-shirt. That's who he was then.

Now? Sadly, Khan is a fringe politician in Pakistan whose lines on Islam and geopolitics these days turn his faithful red with embarrassment. The man may have felt some embarrassment himself when the first news flash appeared from Christopher Sandford's unauthorised *Imran Khan The Biography*. It talked about Khan's alleged affair with a fellow Pakistani student at Oxford who went on to become prime minister. That was the late Benazir Bhutto and boy, did that news run for a few days.

Along with writing about English cricket respectables like Godfrey Evans and Tom Graveney, the author's track record also includes a juicy list of biographies of Eric Clapton, Bruce Springsteen, Roman Polanski and Kurt Cobain.

So a similar cocktail on Imran and Benazir was to be expected. Sadly for

the bazaar gossip bunch, all that the book contains is a few paragraphs on the two and their 'blushing' and 'giggling' when seen together as students. Even more sadly for historians, the affair is the author's theory rather than the discovery of a gushing personal diary or letters unearthed between the leader of the Pakistan People's Party and the man behind Tehreek-e-Insaf.

Bhutto, however, is not the only woman on the list of the man she is rumoured to have nicknamed the Lion of Lahore. There are enough accounts of Khan's social life in England where rather than chasing women he fancied, he fully revelled in having them chase him. The book has plenty of stories about the hijinks of English county cricket and the internal wranglings inside the Pakistani cricket team.

Sandford had access to Khan and worked his way through a long list of the cricketer's acquaintances to write a biography that is hefty, full of snippets yet seems only half-serious. Yet despite many cuttishly tell-all parts, Sandford himself seems hugely taken in by the Khan.

The reasons are simple. Even General Zia said the space around Khan was 'physically brightened'. No matter what he did in his personal life, he was a key figure and an instrumental innovator in his sport. No matter what he did in that career, little matched his energy as a social crusader after his cricket. As for the man today, let's just say he's going through a post mid-life crisis in politics.

The book aims at being a celebrity scoop that belongs to these times about a man who belonged to a larger space two decades ago. It is a complete hoot for all those who still fondly remember the cricketer-playboy who ruled the world even though he has turned into a politician out of sync with it.

For a generation which only knows Khan either as an ex-cricketer or a peculiar public figure, all that can be said is, bad luck, kids. ■



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